

Cyclone George

A Category 5 monster strikes Australia's iron heart — and the global economy feels the tremor.

Port Hedland, Western Australia • 2007

■ FAST FACTS

3	FATALITIES	\$2.9bn	TOTAL DAMAGE (2007)
Cat 5	SEVERE CYCLONE	935 hPa	CENTRAL PRESSURE
295	PEAK GUSTS KM/H	2 weeks	PORT HEDLAND SHUT DOWN

TIMELINE

5 Mar 2007
Tropical cyclone develops in the eastern Indian Ocean.
7 Mar
Rapidly intensifies to Category 5; 240 km/h sustained.
8 Mar, 1:50 AM
Eye crosses coast south of Port Hedland. 3 fatalities at work camp.
8 Mar, Morning
Weakens over the Pilbara desert. Mining operations suspended.

In the early hours of 8 March 2007, a Category 5 tropical cyclone crossed the Pilbara coast of Western Australia with sustained winds of 240 km/h. What Cyclone George struck — the iron ore infrastructure of the Pilbara — was the economic engine of Australia's resource boom. When George came ashore, the world felt it.

The Pilbara region is one of the most geologically remarkable places on Earth. Iron ore extracted here feeds the steel mills of Japan, South Korea, and above all, China. The mines of BHP and Rio Tinto were not merely profitable; they were national infrastructure.

“We were sheltering in a demountable. I could hear the steel walls moving. Not vibrating — actually flexing. And then the roof lifted off and we just held onto each other in the dark.”

— Mining camp worker, Ophthalmia Dam site, March 2007

The Human Cost

Three people died — all at the Ophthalmia Dam construction camp operated by FMG. The deaths occurred when prefabricated accommodation buildings were overturned by the cyclone's winds. The tragedy prompted an immediate investigation into structural standards at temporary accommodation facilities at remote mine sites.



Cyclone damage at a Pilbara mining camp — prefabricated accommodation demolished by George's 295 km/h gusts.

A Global Tremor

Iron ore shipments from Port Hedland were suspended for approximately two weeks. Port Hedland ships over 500 million tonnes annually — 80% bound for China. A two-week disruption sent ripples through steel futures markets in Tokyo, London, and Shanghai. Spot iron ore prices climbed. A single tropical cyclone had reached into the global economy with unexpected force.

THE AFTERMATH



Left: An overturned demountable at De Grey Station. Right: A heavy road tanker flipped on the Indee road south of Port Hedland.

MEDIA RECORD — THE FRONT PAGES

THE WEST AUSTRALIAN

“Three Dead as George Hits Pilbara Camp”

The state’s major daily led with the human tragedy.

8 Mar 2007

AUSTRALIAN FINANCIAL REVIEW

“Iron Ore Prices Surge After Port Hedland Shutdown”

The business press tracked spot price movements.

9 Mar 2007

THE AUSTRALIAN

“Are Mining Camps Safe? The Questions George Left Behind”

Investigation into temporary accommodation standards.

Mar 2007

■ LEARNING FOCUS: Local Industries & the Global Economy

A natural disaster in one place can affect people on the other side of the world.

- ✓ **Supply chains** are networks turning raw materials into finished products. A single disrupted link affects every downstream product.
- ✓ **Commodity markets** respond almost instantly to disruptions — a cyclone in WA can change steel prices in Tokyo within hours.
- ✓ **Economic resilience** means building backup suppliers, stockpiles, and alternative routes to absorb shocks.
- ✓ **Workplace safety in disasters** — the three deaths showed FIFO workers in temporary structures face specific vulnerabilities. Safety law was updated.